

Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026



Source: TH

Why in News?

Parliament has passed the **Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026**, which seeks to extend legal protection to **Vande Mataram** by prescribing penalties for obstructing or disrespecting its singing.

What are the Key Highlights of the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026?

- **Amendment to 1971 Act:** The Bill amends the **Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971** to include **Vande Mataram** within its scope.
 - **Section 3 of the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971** prohibits intentionally preventing the singing of the National Anthem (Jana Gana Mana) or causing disturbance to an assembly during its singing. The offence is punishable with imprisonment up to 3 years, a fine, or both, while repeat offenders face a minimum imprisonment of 1 year.
- **Government's Rationale:** The Bill recalls the **24 th January 1950 Constituent Assembly** proceedings, where **Dr. Rajendra Prasad** accorded **Vande Mataram** a status equal to **Jana Gana Mana** , recognising its historic role in the freedom struggle.
 - It seeks to **bridge the legal gap** , as the **National Song** currently lacks statutory protection comparable to that provided to the **National Anthem (Jana Gana Mana)** .

The Amendment at a Glance

Feature/Provision	The Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971 (Original Act)	The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026
Scope of Protection under Section 3	Specific legal protection solely to the Indian National Anthem (Jana Gana Mana).	Expands the scope of Section 3 to include both the National Anthem and the National Song (Vande Mataram).
Prohibited conduct	Penalises whoever intentionally prevents the singing of the Indian National Anthem, or causes disturbance to any assembly engaged in such singing.	Penalises whoever intentionally prevents the singing of the National Anthem or the National Song, or causes disturbance to any assembly engaged in such singing.
Punishment	Imprisonment for a term which may extend to three years, or with fine, or with both.	The punishment remains unchanged.
Repeat convictions	Under Section 3A (added in 2003), anyone convicted a second or subsequent time for an offense under Section 2 or 3 is punishable with imprisonment for a minimum term of one year .	The enhanced penalty of a minimum one-year imprisonment remains in effect. Repeat offenders who intentionally disrupt the singing of <i>Vande Mataram</i> will now also face this mandatory minimum one-year prison sentence.

Key Provisions of the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971

- **Section 2 - National Flag & Constitution:** Prohibits insults to the **National Flag** and the **Constitution of India** (e.g., burning, defacing, desecrating, or showing disrespect). Punishment: **Up to 3 years' imprisonment, fine, or both** .
 - Criticism of the **Constitution, National Flag, or government measures** aimed at securing **lawful amendment or alteration** is **not an offence** .
- **Section 3 - National Anthem:** Prohibits **intentionally preventing the singing of the National Anthem** or **disturbing an assembly during its singing** . Punishment: **Up to 3 years' imprisonment, fine, or both** .
- **Section 3A - Repeat Offences (2003 Amendment):** Prescribes a **minimum imprisonment of 1 year** for **second and subsequent convictions** under **Sections 2 or 3** .

What are the Key Facts About Vande Mataram?

- **Composition:** **Vande Mataram** (meaning "**Mother, I Bow to Thee**") was composed by **Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay** in **Sanskritised Bengali** . It was first published in the Bengali literary journal **Bangadarshan** on **7th November 1875** and was later included in his novel **Anandamath (1882)** .
- **Musical Adaptation:** It was **set to music by Rabindranath Tagore** and emerged as a powerful symbol of **nationalism, unity, and sacrifice** during India's freedom movement.
- **National Song:** The **first two stanzas** were adopted as India's **National Song** by the **Congress Working Committee in 1937** .
 - On **24th January 1950** , **Dr. Rajendra Prasad** affirmed its equal honour alongside **Jana Gana Mana** (National Anthem).
- **Constitutional Position:** The **Constitution does not explicitly recognise a National Song** .
 - Article 51A(a) of the Indian Constitution makes it a Fundamental Duty to abide by the Constitution and respect its ideals and institutions, the National Flag, and the National Anthem

Role in India's Freedom Struggle

- **Symbol of Nationalism:** **Vande Mataram** became the rallying cry of the **Swadeshi Movement** and India's anti-colonial struggle, inspiring devotion to the motherland and resistance against British rule.
- **British Suppression:** Owing to its mobilising power, the **British frequently banned its public singing** and arrested those who chanted it.
- **Congress Adoption:** **Rabindranath Tagore** first sang **Vande Mataram** at the **1896 Calcutta Session of the Indian National Congress** , and it later became a regular feature of Congress sessions.
- **Partition of Bengal (1905):** It was first used as a **political slogan on 7 th August 1905** , becoming the anthem of the **Swadeshi and Anti-Partition Movement** .
 - In 1905, during the anti-partition movement in Bengal, nearly 40,000 people gathered at **Calcutta**

Town Hall and sang Vande Mataram in protest.

- **Nationalist Organisations & Press:** The **Bande Mataram Sampradaya (1905)** promoted patriotic awareness, while the **English daily *Bande Mataram* (1906)** , led by **Bipin Chandra Pal** and **Sri Aurobindo** , became an influential nationalist publication.
- **Hyderabad-Karnataka Movement (1938):** Students in the **Vande Mataram Movement** defied colonial restrictions by singing the song, resulting in arrests and expulsions.
- **Global Influence:** **Madam Bhikaji Cama** unfurled India's tricolour bearing "**Vande Mataram**" at **Stuttgart (1907)** , **Madan Lal Dhingra** reportedly uttered "Bande Mataram" before his execution in **1909** , and nationalist publications carrying the same name were circulated from **Geneva** .

Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) Protocol on Vande Mataram and Jana Gana Mana

- **Order of Play:** When both are performed, **Vande Mataram (National Song)** must be sung/played **before *Jana Gana Mana* (National Anthem)** .
- **Mandatory Respect:** People must **stand to attention** during the official rendition of **Vande Mataram** (about **3 minutes 10 seconds**). Standing is **not required** when it is played in films, documentaries, or newsreels.
- **Official Occasions:** The National Song shall be played at **Presidential/Gubernatorial functions** , **Presidential broadcasts** , **National Flag ceremonies** , and **official cultural events** .
- **Band Protocol:** When performed by a band, it should be **preceded by a roll of drums** to alert the audience.
- **Schools:** Schools are encouraged to begin the day with **community singing of Vande Mataram** and promote respect for both the **National Song and National Anthem** .
- **Constitutional Basis:** The protocol reinforces the **Fundamental Duty under Article 51A(a)** to respect India's national symbols.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the objective of the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026?

The Bill seeks to **extend legal protection to *Vande Mataram*** by penalising acts of **obstruction or disrespect during its singing** , in addition to existing protections for national symbols.

2. What is the constitutional status of *Vande Mataram* ?

The **Constitution does not explicitly recognise a National Song** . However, the **first two stanzas** of *Vande Mataram* were accorded the status of **National Song** , while **Article 51A(a)** requires citizens to respect the **National Flag** and **National Anthem** .

3. Why is *Vande Mataram* significant in India's freedom struggle?

It became the **rallying cry of the Swadeshi Movement** , inspired nationalist resistance against British rule, and served as a powerful symbol of **unity, sacrifice, and patriotism** .

4. Who composed *Vande Mataram* and where was it first published?

Vande Mataram was composed by **Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay** , first published in **Bangadarshan (1875)** , and later included in his novel **Anandamath (1882)** .

5. How did *Vande Mataram* influence the Indian nationalist movement?

The song inspired **mass protests, Congress sessions, revolutionary movements, and overseas nationalist campaigns** , becoming an enduring symbol of India's struggle for independence.

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/NHLNea0Xts8>

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UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims:

Q. Who among the following is associated with 'Songs from Prison', a translation of ancient Indian religious lyrics in English? (2021)

- (a) Bal Gangadhar Tilak
- (b) Jawaharlal Nehru
- (c) Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi
- (d) Sarojini Naidu

Ans: (c)

Q. What is the number of spokes in the Dharmachakra in the National Flag of India? (2008)

- (a) 16
- (b) 18
- (c) 22
- (d) 24

Ans: (d)

Strengthening India's Sports Ecosystem



Source: PIB

Why in News?

The Government highlighted India's progress towards becoming a sporting nation as the country participates in the **Commonwealth Games in Glasgow**, continuing its **legacy since 1934**.

- It emphasised **India's youthful population as its greatest sporting asset** and highlighted the **Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports'** efforts to promote youth development and sporting excellence.

How is the Khelo India Scheme Transforming India's Sports Ecosystem?

- **Unified Sports Development Framework:** Launched in 2017, the **Khelo India Scheme** merged the **Rajiv Gandhi Khel Abhiyan, Urban Sports Infrastructure Scheme and National Sports Talent Search Scheme** into a comprehensive framework for sports development.
- **Five Key Pillars:** The scheme focuses on **establishing training centres, strengthening coaches and support staff, expanding sports science and technology, organising competitions and leagues** and developing modern sports infrastructure.
- **District-Level Expansion:** The mission aims to establish **one Khelo India Training Centre in every district** through coordinated plans of States and Union Territories.
- **Scientific Athlete Development:** Structured athlete pathways are supported through sports science, psychology, nutrition and data-driven platforms that enable real-time monitoring of athlete performance.
- **Long-Term Vision:** The integrated approach seeks to build a strong grassroots-to-elite sports ecosystem and position **India among the world's leading sporting nations by 2036**.



How are the Khelo India Games Nurturing Future Champions?

- **Beginning of the Games:** The Khelo India movement entered a new phase with the launch of the **Khelo India School Games in New Delhi in 2018**, providing young athletes from across India with a national competitive platform.
- **Khelo India Youth Games:** After the **Indian Olympic Association** joined the initiative, the event was renamed the **Khelo India Youth Games in 2019**. It remains the flagship competition under the Khelo India programme.
- **Expanding Participation:** The Games bring together athletes representing their States and universities, offering competitive exposure and preparing them for national and international events. Since 2018, more than 63,000 athletes have participated.
- **University and Winter Games:** The **Khelo India University Games** and **Khelo India Winter Games** were introduced in 2020 to extend sporting opportunities to university athletes and winter-sport disciplines.
- **Inclusive Sports Platform:** The **Khelo India Para Games** were launched in 2023 to promote competitive opportunities and greater inclusion for para-athletes.
- **New Sporting Formats:** The **Khelo India Beach Games** and **Khelo India Water Sports Festival** were introduced in 2025, expanding the programme to beach and water-based sports.
- **Promotion of Tribal Talent:** The **Khelo India Tribal Games** made their debut in 2026 to identify and showcase sporting talent from tribal communities.



How are Key Initiatives Enabling India's Sporting Success?

- **Union Budget Allocation** : With nearly **65% of India's population below 35 years of age**, the country has a vast pool of sporting talent, supported by a record allocation of ₹4,479.88 crore to the Ministry in the **Union Budget 2026-27** , up from ₹1,219 crore in 2013-14.
- **Target Olympic Podium Scheme:** The **Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports** launched the **Target Olympic Podium Scheme (TOPS) in September 2014** to improve India's performance at the Olympic and Paralympic Games.
 - The scheme was revamped in April 2018 with a dedicated technical support team to provide athletes with comprehensive assistance.
 - It provides elite athletes with foreign training, international competition exposure, specialised coaching, equipment and a monthly stipend of ₹50,000. Its Development Group supports junior athletes with ₹25,000 per month.
 - As of April 2026, the scheme supported 51 Core Athletes, 52 Para Core Athletes and 130 Development Athletes. It contributed significantly to India's medal performances at the **Tokyo 2020** and **Paris 2024 Olympic Games** .
- **Khelo India Rising Talent Identification (KIRTI):** **Khelo India Rising Talent Identification** identifies sporting talent among children aged 9-18 through standardised assessment protocols, Talent Assessment Centres and technologies such as artificial intelligence and data analytics. The initiative aims to help India become a top 10 sporting nation by 2036 and a top five sporting nation by 2047.
 - A total of 174 Talent Assessment Centres operate across three States and Union Territories, with 1,87,921 assessments completed.
- **Sports Goods Manufacturing Initiative:** The **Union Budget 2026-27** allocated ₹500 crore to strengthen domestic sports goods manufacturing and establish India as a global hub for high-quality and affordable sporting equipment.
 - The initiative promotes production capacity, research and innovation, advanced material sciences, participation in global supply chains and employment generation across manufacturing and allied sectors.

How Is India Rising on the Global Sporting Stage?

- **Olympic Progress:** India's [Olympic](#) medal tally increased from two medals at Rio 2016 to seven at Tokyo 2020 and six at Paris 2024. India fielded 117 athletes at Rio, 119 at Tokyo, and 117 at Paris.
 - Neeraj Chopra became India's first Olympic gold medallist in athletics at Tokyo 2020, while Mirabai Chanu emerged as one of the country's most consistent Olympic performers.
- **Paralympic Transformation:** India's [Paralympic](#) medal tally rose from four at Rio 2016 to 19 at Tokyo 2020 and a record 29 at Paris 2024.
 - India sent 84 para-athletes to Paris 2024 and secured seven gold, nine silver, and 13 bronze medals. Avani Lekhara, Sumit Antil, and Pramod Bhagat have been among India's prominent para-athletes.
- **Asian Games Success:** India improved from 57 medals at Incheon 2014 to 69 at Jakarta 2018 and achieved its highest-ever tally of 107 medals at Hangzhou 2023 [Asian Games](#) .
 - The 655-member Indian contingent won 28 gold, 38 silver, and 41 bronze medals. Neeraj Chopra, Lovlina Borgohain, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy, and Chirag Shetty were among the leading performers.
- **Commonwealth Games Strength:** India won 64 medals at Glasgow 2014, 66 at Gold Coast 2018, and 61 at Birmingham 2022, maintaining its position among the leading Commonwealth sporting nations.
- **Key Sporting Disciplines:** Wrestling, weightlifting, table tennis, badminton, and athletics have consistently contributed to India's Commonwealth Games success, with athletes such as P. V. Sindhu, Vinesh Phogat, and Achinta Sheuli delivering notable performances.

Read More: 23rd Commonwealth Games 2026

Conclusion

India's sporting journey is moving from participation to performance and from isolated success to a structured national ecosystem. Khelo India, TOPS, KIRTI, sports infrastructure, sports science and sports manufacturing are building a strong foundation for international excellence. As India competes at the Commonwealth Games 2026 and looks towards future global events, sustained investment and inclusive talent development will be central to making India a true sporting nation.

Drishti Mains Question

India's sports ecosystem is shifting from individual brilliance to institutionalised talent development. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is Khelo India?

Khelo India is a national sports development scheme launched in 2017 to promote grassroots participation, talent identification, sports infrastructure and excellence.

2. What is TOPS?

The Target Olympic Podium Scheme supports elite and emerging athletes for Olympic and Paralympic success through training, equipment, exposure and financial assistance.

3. What is KIRTI?

KIRTI is the Khelo India Rising Talent Identification initiative for identifying sports talent among children aged 9 to 18 years.

4. What is India's performance at Paris Paralympics 2024?

India won **29 medals** , including **7 gold, 9 silver and 13 bronze** , marking its best-ever Paralympic campaign.

5. Where are the Commonwealth Games 2026 being held?

The Commonwealth Games 2026 are being held in **Glasgow from 23 July to 2 August 2026** .

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/Q3Rvro6AxPE>]

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. Consider the following pairs with regard to sports awards

	Award	Given For
1.	Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna Award	For the most spectacular and outstanding performance by a sportsperson over a period of the last four years
2.	Arjuna Award	For lifetime achievement by a sportsperson
3.	Dronacharya Award	To honour eminent coaches who have successfully trained sportspersons or teams
4.	Rashtriya Khel Protsahan Puraskar	To recognise the contribution made by sportspersons even after their retirement

How many of the above pairs are correctly matched?

- a) Only one
- b) Only two
- c) All three
- d) All four

Ans: (b)

Q. Consider the following statements in respect of the 32nd Summer Olympics: (2021)

- 1. The official motto for this Olympics is 'A New World'.
- 2. Sport Climbing, Surfing, Skateboarding, Karate and Baseball are included in this Olympics.

Which of the above statements is/are correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 only
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Ans: (b)

SC Verdict on Ex Post Facto Environmental Clearances



Source: TH

The Supreme Court has **quashed the Centre's 2021 Office Memorandum on ex post facto Environmental Clearances (ECs)** , reaffirming that **prior ECs under the Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) Notification, 2006** is mandatory.

- The Court held that retrospective environmental regularisation must be granted **only through a statutory notification under the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986** , not an administrative order , as such orders **cannot create a perpetual, parallel amnesty regime** .
 - The Court held that the perpetual 2021 Office Memorandum promoted a '**pollute and then pay**' approach, failing the **tests of proportionality and reasonable classification** , thereby violating **Article 14 (Right to Equality)** and **Article 21 (Right to Life and a Clean Environment)** .
 - Prior, ECs already granted under the 2017 Notification and 2021 OM remain valid unless individually challenged. Any future amnesties require a valid statutory notification under **Section 3 of the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986** .
- **Supervening Public Interest:** Retrospective clearances are not entirely barred but must be restricted to a "**narrow, time-bound, reasoned, and supervised window**" applicable only to projects of immense public utility (e.g., hospitals, airports, strategic infrastructure) **under Section 3 of the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986** .
- **Ex Post Facto EC:** Refers to **retrospective environmental clearance** granted to projects that started without prior approval.
- **Shift in Environmental Jurisprudence:** The judgment marks a nuanced transition from an absolutist application of the **precautionary principle** to balancing it with the **polluter pays principle** and **sustainable development** , acknowledging the heavy socioeconomic and environmental costs (like debris and wasted resources) of demolishing massive, integrated public infrastructure.
- **Mandate of the 2006 EIA Notification:** The overarching legal principle remains that "**prior environmental clearance**" is **mandatory** before the commencement of construction or operations to evaluate ecological impacts, hear public objections, and prescribe safeguards.

Read more: [SC Recalls Verdict Blocking Retrospective Environmental Clearances](#)



Source:TH

On **Global Tiger Day (29 th July 2026)** , India reaffirmed its commitment to **tiger conservation** through **scientific management, responsible eco-tourism, capacity building, and public participation** , while highlighting its remarkable achievements in protecting **tigers and their habitats** .

- **Global Tiger Day:** Established at the **2010 St. Petersburg Tiger Summit (Russia)** , where the **13 Tiger Range Countries (TRCs)** - **Bangladesh, Bhutan, Cambodia, China, India, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, Nepal, Russia, Thailand, and Vietnam** including **India** , adopted the **St. Petersburg Declaration** , launched the **Global Tiger Recovery Programme (GTRP)** , and committed to the **TX2 Goal** of doubling the global wild tiger population by **2022** (the global TX2 Goal was not fully achieved).
 - The day promotes **habitat conservation, anti-poaching efforts, international cooperation, and human-tiger coexistence** to ensure the long-term survival of wild tigers.
 - **IUCN** has adopted "**Coexistence in Action: Scaling Solutions for People and Tigers**" as the **theme for Global Tiger Day 2026** , highlighting **human-tiger coexistence** through locally led conservation solutions in shared landscapes.
- **Key Highlights of Global Tiger Day 2026:**
 - **IUCN Initiative:** The **Integrated Tiger Habitat Conservation Programme (ITHCP)** supports habitat restoration, anti-poaching efforts, and community-led coexistence across Asia.
 - **NTCA Eco-tourism Webpage (2026):** **National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA)** launched an Integrated platform for **authentic safari and accommodation bookings** , promoting **responsible eco-tourism** .
- **Tiger Population in India:** India's **tiger population reached 3,682** , while the number of **Tiger Reserves increased to 58** .
- **India's Major Tiger Conservation Initiatives:**
 - **Project Tiger (1973):** Flagship programme launched to ensure the **protection and recovery of wild tiger populations** and their habitats.
 - India's **tiger population reached 3,682** , while the number of **Tiger Reserves increased to 58** .
 - **National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA):** Statutory body established under the **Wild Life (Protection) Act, 1972** to strengthen tiger conservation.
 - **All India Tiger Estimation (AITE):** Conducted every **4 years** using **camera traps, GIS, and M-STripES** (Monitoring System for Tigers – Intensive Protection and Ecological Status) for scientific tiger monitoring.
 - **International Big Cat Alliance (IBCA):** India-led global initiative for the conservation of **seven big cat species** .

TIGER

Royal Bengal Tiger (*Panthera Tigris*) is the National animal of India.

Subspecies of Tiger

- * The continental (*Panthera tigris tigris*)
- * The Sunda (*Panthera tigris sondaica*)

Habitat

Tropical rainforests, evergreen forests, temperate forests, mangrove swamps, grasslands, and savannas



Countries Where Tiger Population Is Found

- Found only in 13 Tiger Range countries- India, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Russia, China, Thailand, Malaysia, Indonesia, Cambodia, Laos, and Vietnam
- As per the latest report by IUCN, tiger has gone extinct in Cambodia, Laos, and Vietnam

Protection Status

- IUCN Red List: Endangered
- CITES: Appendix I
- WPA 1972: Schedule I

Threats

- Habitat loss
- Poaching and illegal trade
- Human-Wildlife conflict

Conservation Efforts

- International Big Cats Alliance (IBCA): For conservation of seven big cats namely Tiger, Lion, Leopard, Snow Leopard, Cheetah, Jaguar and Puma (launched by India)
- Tx2 campaign: Launched by WWF; stands for 'Tiger times 2' signaling the goal to double the tiger population by 2022
- National Tiger Conservation authority (NTCA): Constituted under the WPA, 1972
- Project Tiger: Launched in 1973
- Tiger Census: Every 4 years

Tigers In India

- India has the largest population
 - As of 2022, India has 3167 tigers
 - Largest population has been found in Central Indian Highlands & Eastern Ghats Landscape
- Tiger Reserves: India now has 53 tiger reserves
 - Ranipur in UP is the latest
 - Nagarjun Sagar (Andhra Pradesh) is the largest while Orang (Assam) is the smallest (Core area)



Drishti IAS

Read more: [Project Tiger](#)